

results would have been better. And I think I am just not willing to make those mistakes again ever," she says.

To correct what she felt was one of the big mistakes of the Tokyo Olympics build-up, she called up Rana.

"I think the turning point for me in this Olympic cycle has been when I started working with Jaspal sir once again. I called him up on the 14th of June last year, but I had been thinking about it for at least six months prior. Every time I thought about reaching out, I banished those thoughts because I felt I might just be trying to find excuses to justify my reality — which was that I didn't enjoy shooting. I knew what was missing in my shooting was having Jaspal sir coaching me, but I didn't have the courage to reach out to him. After everything that had happened in the past, I didn't know whether it would work out or not. Finally, though, I had enough. I was so sick of shooting, and I felt I just needed to call him. I had no idea whether it would work or whether it would be a terrible decision. But I needed to give it a shot," she says.

Rana says he felt compelled to accept her request. "I can't think how much courage she must have had to call me and ask for my help. If I was in her place, I wouldn't have called me. What happened between us was not my fault, but it wasn't her fault either. It's hard to be the first person to reach out even when you are at fault. In Manu's case, she wasn't to blame. She was misinformed about my intentions. If she could find it in her to overcome whatever ego she might have felt, how could I have refused to work with her?" he says.

The early days of their re-partnership weren't easy. "After what happened before the Olympics, I just stopped coming to the Karni Singh range (in Delhi). It was just really uncomfortable. I had my own businesses to run in Dehradun, and I had restarted my political career in Uttarakhand. But I knew I had to

« Weapon troubles are now a thing of the past for Manu as Rana makes sure her pistol is thoroughly checked »»

go back to Delhi to work with Manu," he says.

It wasn't just his physical presence but also a wealth of technical knowledge that Rana brought to the table. At the selection trials in Bhopal, Rana meticulously notes down every one of Manu's shots on a custom-made app. He also keeps a writing pad where he draws out maps of her shooting pattern, which looks like a cross between a doctor's prescription and a wizard's incantation.

He's as demanding as he ever was. "There are times during trials where I've almost given up and started to release shots without going through my process of aiming,

just to get the series over with. But Jaspal sir always catches on. And he'll be furious. He doesn't mind a bad series, but he hates nothing more than a shooter giving less than 100 percent," she says.

While her coach might be stern, weapon troubles are now a thing of the past. "I was having malfunctions with my pistol not just at the Olympics but even after it. I even had trouble with my pistol in the first and second shooting trials in Bhopal last year. I was always wondering what was going wrong. My pistol was fine, my ammunition was brand new as were my magazines. I was completely clueless on what was going on. Ever since I've started working with Jaspal sir once again, I've stopped having any issues. He usually just cleans my pistol once every six months. He's a lot more knowledgeable than a lot of coaches. He checks everything in the pistol — all the parts and spares. He makes sure that nothing can go wrong. He makes sure that I have three or four spare pistol grips, not just two. I've not had any issues with my equipment ever since," she says.

Rana and Manu changed up her training pattern as well. "I think the main reason I really considered giving up shooting was that for a long time I was working like a *gadha* (donkey). Jaspal sir tells me I was working like a *khacchar* (mule) instead of actually working like a *ghoda* (horse). I was doing just brainless hard work. And I needed to know the difference," she says.

"Jaspal sir encourages me to try different things. His only requirement is that I don't do it at the expense of my shooting or practise it throughout the day. So he encourages me to try different



RITU RAJ KONWAR